MEN WHO MATTER From left, Bihar CM Nitish Kumar, RJD patriarch Lalu Yadav with son Tejaswi Yadav





Photographs: **ANI**

BIHAR

LALU'S OLIVE BRANCH GAMBIT

By Amitabh Srivastava

Winter may be intensifying in Bihar but the state's political climate is anything but cool. On December 30, Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) patriarch Lalu Prasad Yadav extended an unexpected olive branch to Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, offering to "forgive" his volte-faces and keeping the "doors always open" for reconciliation. With Nitish as well as Lalu's son Tejaswi Yadav ruling out any such reconciliation, this dramatic overture has injected fresh intrigue into Bihar's evolving political script ahead of the assembly election due later this year.

The timing is notable. Nitish's Janata Dal (United) has been asserting its leadership ambitions with a vigour that leaves little room for ambiguity. On December 21, the party flooded social media with bold declarations like *'Jab baat Bihar ki ho, naam sirf Nitish Kumar ka ho* (When it comes to Bihar, only Nitish Kumar matters)'. It was widely interpreted as a retort to Union home minister Amit Shah's recent comments, which hinted at a potential change in the Bharatiya Janata Party's strategy for Bihar. As it fuelled speculations about a Maharashtra-style shake-up, the BJP quickly announced that Nitish would lead the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) into the 2025 state election.

Lalu's gesture, far from a casual overture, serves as a sharp reminder of the BJP's rocky history with its allies. The 2020 assembly election is a case in point, when Chirag Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party fielded candidates against the JD(U), undercutting Nitish's prospects. While the JD(U) then emerged with only 43 seats in the 243-member Vidhan Sabha, the 2024 Lok Sabha election told a different story—the party led in 74 assembly segments, outpacing the BJP's 68 and the RJD's 35. The numbers also undergird Nitish's significance within the NDA, particularly for Prime Minister Narendra Modi, whose government's parliamentary majority is well short of the halfway mark.

The divergence between Lalu and Tejaswi's public stances adds another layer to this drama. "Nitish Kumar's days are over," declared Tejaswi, rejecting any talk of reconciliation. A calculated dual strategy seems to be at play, more than any serious difference of opinion. While Lalu remains rooted in

WHERE THEY STAND

- **RJD patriatch Lalu Yadav says his "doors always open" for CM Nitish Kumar. But son Tejaswi Yadav firmly rejects any reconciliation**
- **Nitish, too, rules out the possibility of quitting the NDA; the BJP has officially declared that he will lead the alliance into the 2025 polls**